

project.org

STUDENT HANDOUT

YELLOW LEVEL
GRADE LEVEL

The Numbers in the Coins

Grades 5–8 · Math

James Tissot (1836–1902), Brooklyn Museum

ADMIT ONE

NAME _____ DATE _____ CLASS _____

Every coin in *In Their Hands* carries numbers: dates, reigns, weights, sizes, amounts. To work with the dates you need one rule that surprises most people: **there is no year zero.** The year 1 BC is followed straight away by AD 1.

01 PART 1 The rule



Both dates AD, or both BC: subtract. **From BC to AD:** add the two numbers, then take away 1.

The Shekel of Tyre in this exhibition (a replica) is dated **1 BC–AD 1**. How many years apart are those dates? Why is the answer not 2?

02 PART 2 Six spans

Find each span, then rank all six from longest to shortest.

WHO	DATES IN THE EXHIBITION	WORKING	YEARS
Augustus rules	27 BC–AD 14		
Herod the Great rules	37 BC–4 BC		
Aretas IV (his coin)	9 BC–AD 40		
Herod Antipas (his coin, a replica)	4 BC–AD 39		
Herod Agrippa I (his coin)	AD 41–44		
Claudius reigns	AD 41–54		

Longest to shortest: _____



CASE 7 · PONTIUS PILATE · BRONZE PRUTAH · AUTHENTIC

AD 29/30, year 16 of Tiberius · 1.79 g · 16 mm

Pilate was prefect of Judaea from AD 26 to 36, and this coin was minted in the year of the Passion. It is dated by the emperor's reign: Tiberius began to reign in AD 14, and that first year counts as year 1.

03 PART 3 — Year 16 of Tiberius

Year 16 of Tiberius began in AD _____ Show how: _____

How many years after Pilate arrived was the coin made? _____

04 PART 4 — Grams and millimeters

a. Herod Agrippa I's prutah weighs **1.80 g**. Which is heavier, his or Pilate's, and by how much? _____

b. What do the two coins weigh together? _____

c. How many of Pilate's coins fit edge to edge along a 30 cm ruler? _____

d. Claudius' coin is an **AE27**: bronze, 27 mm across. How much wider is it than Pilate's? _____

05 PART 5 — Thirty pieces of silver

Every Jewish man over twenty owed a **half-shekel** to the Temple each year. Judas was paid thirty pieces of silver, almost certainly Tyrian shekels.

Half-shekel : shekel = _____ Thirty shekels pay one year's tax for _____ men.

06 PART 6 — Who gave more?

> *They all gave out of their wealth; but she, out of her poverty, put in everything — all she had to live on.*
>
> MARK 12:44

Invented numbers: A has 400 coins and gives 40. B has 50 and gives 25. The widow has 2 lepta and gives 2. Find each percent; rank by amount, then by percent. What did Jesus mean?

MINI MUSEUM CONNECTION

Walk the Gospel Timeline online and check each span from Part 2 as you pass its coin.

minimuseumproject.org/exhibitions/in-their-hands